# Green Sea Turtles Are Bouncing Back -- But the Job Isn't Done

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On a quiet beach after dark, a green sea turtle hauls herself out of the ocean and up the sand, leaving a trail of alternating flipper marks that look like tire tracks from a monster truck. She is looking for a place to lay her eggs. On Aldabra, a remote **atoll** 400 miles off the eastern coast of Africa, that sight is far more common than it was 50 years ago.

Green turtles were once hunted heavily for meat, leather, and eggs. At the end of the 19th century, as many as 12,000 green turtles were captured at Aldabra in a single year. By the 1960s, annual nests on the **atoll** had fallen to just 2,000 to 3,000.

A hunting ban in 1968 gave Aldabra's turtles a key safeguard. Researchers at the **atoll**'s station fewer than three dozen people live there have now tracked nesting turtles for more than half a century. The wait was long because green turtles do not start breeding until they are 25 to 35 years old, so a generation born under protection needed decades to return. But return they did: in 2019, staff estimated more than 15,000 **clutches** of eggs across the **atoll**, a 173 percent increase since 1980. On Settlement Beach alone, researchers can find close to 100 turtles in one night at peak season.

The comeback is global. In October 2025, the International Union for **Conservation** of Nature moved green turtles from endangered to least concern. The IUCN estimated worldwide numbers have risen roughly 28 percent since the 1970s, and a separate 2025 assessment found 8 of their 11 regional populations at low risk.

Satellite tracking shows why one beach matters so much: turtles from Aldabra travel more than 1,500 miles, fanning out like the crooked spokes of a wheel to feed on **seagrass** as far away as Somalia, Mozambique, and the southern tip of Madagascar.

But the recovery is uneven. A small population in the south-central Pacific remains in serious trouble from **bycatch**, hunting, and climate change, and other populations in the East Pacific, southwest Pacific, and North Indian Oceans are **vulnerable**. Environmental economist Adam Pritchard calls it a **conservation** success story and adds that the work is definitely not done.

## Word Treasure

**atoll** -- A ring-shaped island made of coral, around a lagoon.

**clutches** -- Groups of eggs laid by one animal at one time.

**bycatch** -- Animals caught by accident while fishers are trying to catch something else.

**seagrass** -- Grass-like plants that grow in the sea and that turtles eat.

**vulnerable** -- In danger or at risk of harm.

**conservation** -- Work to protect animals and nature.

## Background you need

Green sea turtles are large sea animals that come ashore to lay eggs in sandy nests on beaches.

For a long time people hunted them for food and other products, which pushed their numbers down.

A hunting ban protects them, and researchers count nests to track whether the population is recovering.

Because turtles take many years to start breeding, a recovery can take decades to show up.

## Break it down

**LEAD:** Green sea turtles are bouncing back at Aldabra, but the job is not done

**KEY EVENT:** Protection and decades of nest tracking have brought a strong recovery

+- HISTORY: Hunting for meat, leather, and eggs cut annual nests to 2,000 to 3,000 by the 1960s

+- TURNING POINT: A hunting ban in 1968 gave Aldabra's turtles a key safeguard

+- EVIDENCE: More than 15,000 clutches were estimated in 2019, a 173 percent rise since 1980

+- GLOBAL: The IUCN moved green turtles from endangered to least concern in October 2025

**RANGE:** Satellite tracking shows Aldabra turtles travel more than 1,500 miles to feed on seagrass

**OPEN QUESTION:** Whether struggling populations, such as the south-central Pacific group, can recover

## Why it matters

Aldabra's recovery shows that long-term protection can bring a hunted species back, but the uneven picture means conservation work still matters for the populations that remain at risk.

## Test what you remember

**1. Where is Aldabra?**

- (A) An island off Mozambique
- (B) A remote atoll 400 miles off the eastern coast of Africa
- (C) The southern tip of Madagascar
- (D) A beach in Somalia

**2. Why did the turtle recovery take so long to show?**

- (A) Turtles travel only a short distance to feed
- (B) Researchers counted nests for only one year
- (C) The hunting ban lasted only a few years
- (D) Green turtles do not start breeding until they are 25 to 35 years old

**3. What did researchers estimate in 2019?**

- (A) More than 15,000 clutches of eggs across the atoll
- (B) The start of the hunting ban
- (C) Nests falling to 2,000 to 3,000
- (D) A change in the turtles' IUCN status

**4. What did the IUCN do in October 2025?**

- (A) Banned hunting at Aldabra
- (B) Moved green turtles from least concern to endangered
- (C) Declared all populations safe
- (D) Moved green turtles from endangered to least concern

**5. How far do turtles from Aldabra travel?**

- (A) 15,000 miles
- (B) 400 miles
- (C) 100 miles
- (D) More than 1,500 miles

**6. Which population remains in serious trouble?**

- (A) A small population in the south-central Pacific
- (B) All 11 regional populations
- (C) The population at Settlement Beach
- (D) The population in Somalia

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: B 2: D 3: A 4: D 5: D 6: A

## Questions to think about

**1. Adam Pritchard, environmental economist: Calls the recovery a conservation success story, but adds that the work is definitely not done.**

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):